

It has been a long while since the first laptop made its way on to store shelves. What led to the invention of a laptop was the necessity of a portable computer that could be lugged around and also worked on, in the absence of direct power supply. All went well until mobile phones with Internet connectivity came along, and that changed the whole dynamics of mobile computing.

The mobile Internet, coupled with Internet hot-spots, fuelled the craze of 'anytime, anywhere computing' and suddenly we found our traditional laptops very heavy, cumbersome and in need of more electrical juice. And then, increased bandwidth and more powerful Web apps gave people the possibility of fulfilling all their computing needs online. Thus emerged a new breed of computers, christened 'netbooks'.

What is a netbook?

In Wikipedia's words, "...netbooks are small, light and inexpensive laptop computers suited for general computing and accessing Web-based applications; they are often marketed as 'companion devices,' that is, to augment a user's other computer access."

A typical netbook ranges from 8 inches (20.3 cm) to 11.6 inches (29.5 cm), with smaller keyboards, reduced computing power, fewer ports and no optical drives. Because of their small size and low computing power, the normal operating systems that we are so accustomed to in our daily use, aren't the most ideal. This gave rise to the need of customising the existing operating systems so

that they fitted into a netbook's size and form, without compromising too much on the performance.

What are the operating systems that run on a netbook?

UI designers need to be given utmost flexibility and importance, when it comes to designing an operating system tailor-made for a netbook. Some of the challenges faced while building an OS for a netbook are:

1. The screen size is much smaller compared to a traditional 14-inch (35.6 cm) notebook.
2. The display resolution of a netbook hardly ever crosses 1024 x 768.

The Atom processor has done wonders in increasing the battery life of netbooks. This, coupled with the smaller display, and the way an operating system is coded, play a big role in optimising the battery life.

Windows XP had been shipped with almost every netbook since the very first of the breed ever left the factory. However, a lot of manufacturers are now gungho about the much-optimised Windows 7 and are hurrying to bundle the OS with their machines.

But then, how about the world of open source?

Yes, we are getting to it. :-) It is in the world of open source that most of the operating systems, that are tailor-made for netbooks, have emerged. While Ubuntu had always been in the lead, with the Ubuntu (and Kubuntu) Netbook Remix, Intel is also inching forward with its much celebrated Moblin (recently out of beta and now launched as v2.1). Then there is one of the most interesting distributions we have come across—JoliCloud, developed by Tariq Krim (founder of Netvibes), and based upon Ubuntu Netbook Remix.

What's more, even Google decided not to be left behind and announced its spanking new Chrome OS. We also got to know that Acer has started to offer its Aspire One D250 with dual booting options—Windows XP and Google's Android.

The netbook industry is growing in leaps and bounds. Today, almost every social media entrepreneur sports a netbook. It's the best time for a year-end wrap-up of Linux-based operating systems and also the netbooks that are on offer, today.

However, on a note of regret—while we were promised netbooks from Lenovo, Sony, Acer, ASUS, Dell and Samsung, we finally got trial models only from Acer and ASUS. The rest decided to back out at the last moment since they wanted to test their products with the newly released Windows 7 before they sent them out for review. The fact that we informed them we didn't even plan to boot Windows on their machines, didn't help matters. We apologise for not being able to come up with detailed reviews of other netbooks in the market.

